Pakistan.[144] To make things worse, the Marri group sought Indian (and US) support for the movement in a televised interview soon after Malik's testimony. In addition to violent attacks, a 'Long March' across Balochistan had been organised to rally support against Islamabad. The situation reached such a crescendo that soon after Malik's allegations, US senator Berman bluntly asked Narayanan what his men in Afghanistan were up to. Taken aback, Narayanan reassured the US delegation that Islamabad's worry that a handful of Indian personnel at the consulates would 'dismember' Pakistan was paranoid. After fifty years in the intelligence business he could assure them that his spies were 'not that good'. If anything, those who thought about strategic threats were focused on China and not Pakistan, a country about which people in India 'don't think much'.[145]

In July 2009, at a meeting in Sharm-el-Sheikh, Manmohan Singh met his Pakistani counterpart, Yousuf Raza Gilani, to assess the possibility of resuming dialogue. India had offered a dossier of evidence showing how the 26/11 attacks were planned and executed from Pakistan's soil and its lone survivor, Ajmal Kasab, was a Pakistani national. In return, Gilani allegedly told Singh that Pakistan had three Ajmal Kasab's to show in Balochistan and had a dossier on the same, and thus, it would be prudent for India to address Pakistan's concerns about Balochistan.[146] Gilani had been cautious and limited in his allegations, but the salvo worked. Singh agreed to discuss Balochistan and the associated role of Indian consulates in Afghanistan and issued a joint statement to that effect.[147] The move backfired domestically with the BJP, the CPM, and government allies such as the Samajwadi Party coupled with members of the Congress terming it a sell out.[148] Blaming Singh for budging under US pressure to 'allay Pakistan's anxieties in Balochistan', the opposition argued that the government had unnecessarily legitimised Pakistan's allegations.[149]

In retrospect, opposition parties failed Manmohan Singh in July 2009. The logic of 'why should we talk about Balochistan when we have nothing to do with it?' was misplaced from a historical standpoint, and went against the grain of conciliatory diplomacy. If anything, it reinforced the notion that Indian agencies were involved in Balochistan. Indian politicians had incorrectly assessed Singh's statement that India had 'nothing to hide' in Balochistan as an admission of